

WEBSITE RE-DESIGN FOR MAXIMUM MARKETING PERFORMANCE

Your website is your marketing home base. In today's landscape, your website is the place where all your communications should be centralized. If you are looking into launching a website re-design, there is one major thing that you need to consider: Your website is your best salesperson.

market 8

Your
Website as
Your Best
Salesperson

Website Re-Design for Maximum Marketing Performance

Your website is your home base for communicating your marketing message – the place where all of your external communications should be centralized. Remember: *Your website is your best salesperson.*

Consider what a good salesperson does for your company:

1. Presents a proper image of your company
2. Explains your overall value proposition
3. Knows your product or service offering at an expert level
4. Adjusts the message according to the audience
5. Demonstrates empathy by truly showing an interest in helping the client, emphasizing value first and foremost
6. Is well-prepared to answer questions of any kind regarding the client's needs, as well as products and services
7. Finds leads (or leads find him)
8. Follows up with leads and completes a process of qualification
9. Keeps your clients updated on new developments
10. Closes the deal at the right moment, without the "hard sell" approach
11. Upsells on every deal based on value
12. Keeps track of his own performance

The best-performing salesperson provides the most value, builds rapport and trust with clients, brings home the most qualified leads and closes the sale without pushing the client. Clients want to buy from him because they trust him and understand the value he brings.

The only reason for you to engage in a website redesign is to take the necessary steps to ensure that your site performs at a level that parallels or beats your best salespeople.

Today, people are living differently than they did just 10 years ago. Most information-seekers conduct dozens of searches per day, and rather than listen to a salesperson, read spam messages or fly to a tradeshow, they find it easier to sit at their desks and find the information online through search engines, or asking their acquaintances to point them in the right direction. Once they are aware, customers will proceed to the research & education stages of their purchase.

This trend is affecting B2B buyers as well:

- Since the recession began, 62% of B2B buyers say they spend more time researching products and services online during the procurement process.¹
- 25% of B2B buyers say they are more likely to change vendors than before the downturn.²
- 65% of the C-Suite conduct 6+ work-related searches daily³
- 99% of small business owners say search engines are the most effective tool for finding suppliers.⁴

65% of the C-suite conduct 6+ work-related searches daily

¹ Google & OTX, B2B Procurement Study 2009

² idem

³ C-level title, business decision-maker at companies with annual revenues \$1B+, Google/Forbes Insights, 2009.

⁴ idem

Turning your website into your best salesperson

To achieve this goal, your website should have the following characteristics:

1. Presents a proper image of your company

First things first, a professional and well-presented image is a prerequisite. Simply put, an outmoded or ineffective image will prevent you from doing anything else successfully in your marketing department. An out-of-date look might signify an out-of-date skill set.

Make your brand image consistent, and make sure it reflects your and your company's personality.

DON'T MISS OUT!

Take care of the basics: your website should look great

If content is
king, design is
definitely the
queen.

2. Explain your overall value proposition

Your website must communicate the value that your company provides. Use simple, easy-to-understand terminology that gets straight to the

point. If you get lost in philosophy and theory, your clients will not understand what you do – or how you can benefit them.

DON'T MISS OUT!

Set up your home page so that your key and most important value proposition comes across clearly within a few seconds

Basic usability: Make sure that your customers know where they are – and why they're on that particular page – at all times

Keep navigation simple: the less navigation levels, the better

DON'T MISS OUT!

Set up pages dedicated to each one of your key products

3. Knows your product or service offering at an expert level

Your website should explain your products and services even more effectively than the best salesperson. A customer will gain a good sense of what you do when you explain your value. Then, you must provide your customer the ability to dig deeper by offering dedicated product pages with detailed information. And you can present succinct one- or two-minute videos or demos that enable your customer to gain a clear grasp of what your product is all about.

4. Finds leads (or leads find him)

During the first two phases of the buying process (initial research, recognition of the opportunity), your buyer will most likely find your company via Google searches, from one of the many social media outlets, or from a friend.

99% of small business owners say search engines are the most effective tool for finding suppliers

There is a very good chance your customer will arrive at your blog first.

This is the reason why, as you design your website, you need to have your blog in either a subdomain of your main site (blog.company.com), or within the same URL structure as your main website (company.com/subdomain).

You should always provide the opportunity for your buyer to engage and establish communication with you. In other words: be sure to include the appropriate call to action. This is the core of your website; the very reason it exists.

100%
increase in online
research conducted
across all B2B
industries since 2007

DON'T MISS OUT!

Understand thoroughly the lingo of your buyers – then perform a comprehensive keyword analysis

Set up a blog as part of your main domain

Strictly follow Search Engine Optimization principles throughout your website and your blog

Create calls to action throughout your site to get your visitors involved

Create landing pages where you give your buyers the opportunity to engage

5. Adjusts the message according to the audience

Adjust your message to different audiences. The more complex your product or service is, the more likely you will have different stakeholders and different levels of decision-making. Think how you can talk directly to the various interests of these stakeholders, and develop content to talk to them directly.

For example, if you sell industrial equipment, your client's decision will likely involve several levels of approvals. Operations will take steps to ensure that your company understands their systems, while making sure that your product integrates well with their operations and finding out how your product can increase productivity. The finance C-suite will be interested in understanding the payback time and the risk of the investment. Business cases with quantifiable results will of course be of high interest to this group. The CEO will care more about how this product can make the company more competitive and help it achieve its business goals. He will need a clear understanding of the different aspects of the investment: operations, payback time, and how can it make the company more productive and more competitive.

In your website re-design project, you should consider creating content specific to each one of the decision-making groups.

Also, a good salesperson understands the client's buying process (Figure 1) and knows when to discuss key topics at the right time.

DON'T MISS OUT!

Set up pages dedicated to position your product or service from different angles – i.e. functional and financial – and list the benefits

Define what type of content will be useful for buyers at each stage of the buying process, and position it appropriately through your site and your campaigns

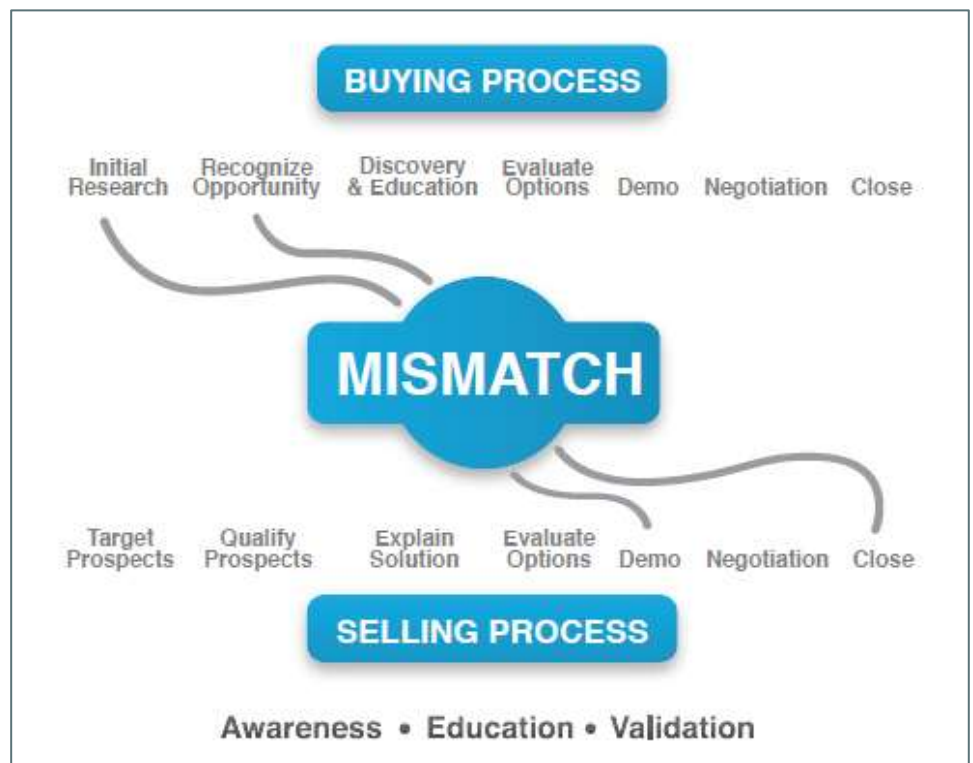


FIGURE 1 - BUYING PROCESS VS. SELLING PROCESS

6. Demonstrates empathy by truly showing an interest in helping the client; provides value first

The fastest way to turn off a potentially good lead is to jump immediately into selling mode. You should concentrate on demonstrating value first through your content. This is the best way to establish trust and interest.

So before you design that landing page for your piece of content, think first what type of content you have that is strictly designed to help the customer, without regard to selling your product, and which content is actually collateral material that explains your product or service and asks for the sale.

You should create landing pages to encourage your customers to voluntarily sign up for information. Once you have provided value first, you can keep providing value by continuing to offer help and tips in your lead-nurturing campaigns.

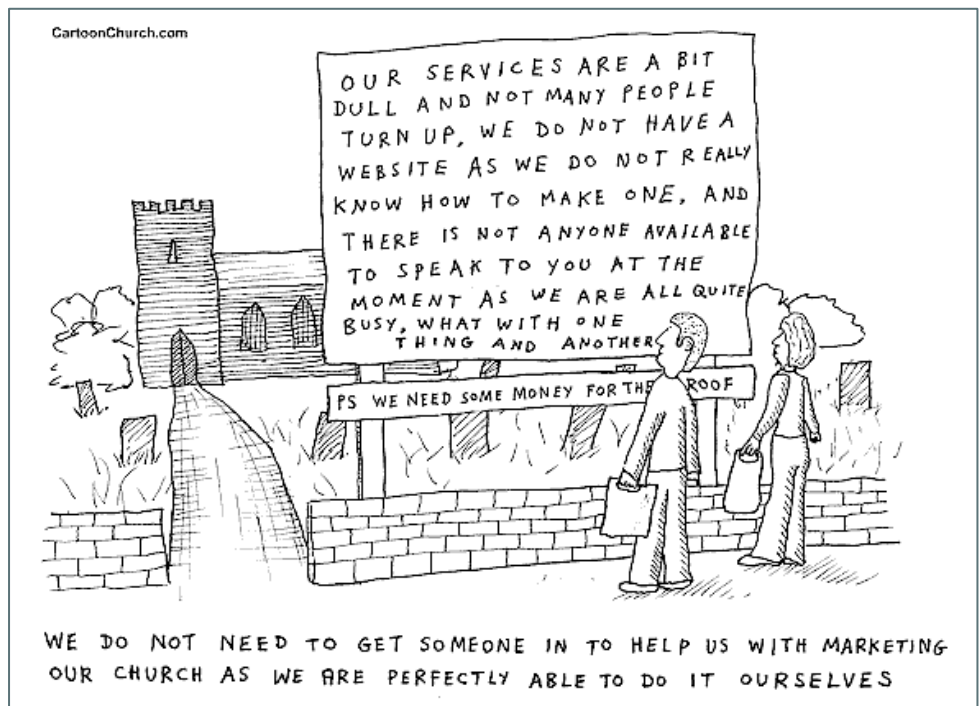
Make sure to avoid creating landing pages that strictly result in the customer receiving a series of sales pitches. Again: provide value first.

DON'T MISS OUT!

Pay it forward: develop content that truly helps your buyer, whether they buy from you or not.

Communicate that content in your blog

Develop tip sheets, white papers, e-books or videos to spread that knowledge.



7. Is well-prepared to answer questions of any kind about the client's needs, and the products or services

Your website is always accessible. Your buyers can go online 24/7 and look up information about your company, your products, or for a reference to materials that help address specific business problems.

Your buyers will develop more specific questions about your product or service once they have completed the initial research and move on to education and discovery, when they will learn more about what your company does. Then, in the evaluation phase, they will gain additional understanding about what your company can do and will begin comparing options.

Make sure you create easy-to-consume content, such as webinars, product showcases and business cases; these are key features to provide buyers in these phases. Your website needs to be completely accessible to your buyers, enabling them to answer the key questions that may arise during every stage of their purchase.

DON'T MISS OUT!

Create webinars, business cases and other content that talks at length about how your product or service functions

76% of
consumers want a
website that makes it
easy to find what they
want.

8. Follows up with leads and completes a process of qualification

A good salesperson will make sure that leads go through a process of qualification. The best qualification process is one in which the customer qualifies himself. He can achieve this by making sure that he reads buying signals during the follow-

up process. If a buyer does not follow through with a purchase after understanding the value your company brings to the table, chances are he is still not ready, or he is simply not a good match for you.

Similarly, a lead-nurturing campaign helps you communicate how your company works and the issues that your company can help solve. If the value is explained well and the value proposition is compelling, there is an excellent chance that your buyer will respond.

If a buyer shows interest, your website analytics should help you identify which buyers have a higher level of interest vs. your less interested prospects by allowing you to measure how they respond to your marketing.

Present at least two calls to action in every touch point: One that offers more general knowledge (which indicates the lead is earlier in the buying process), and one that offers product information, or “next step” type offers (which indicates the lead is closer to a buying decision).

DON'T MISS OUT!

Set up lead nurturing campaigns for leads that engage and show interest

Create at least 2 calls to action on every touch point: one for mid-funnel buyers, and one for top-funnel buyers

9. Keeps your clients updated on new developments

Every time you make an update to your product or service offering, your “best salesperson” should be prepared and ready to communicate to your buyers.

Also, you must build your website using a robust Content Management System so that you can update it as frequently as you need.

DON'T MISS OUT!

Build a dynamic website – don't let it sit still

Make sure that you can easily update your website through a CMS

10. Closes the deal at the right moment, without the “hard sell” approach

Your best salespeople sell without actually pushing for the sale. They have positioned themselves successfully in front of the customer. The buyer clearly understands the value the salesperson brings to the table; the salesperson has

differentiated himself and has eliminated the pricing battle and the competition. The best salespeople do this by adding true value, and by not pushing for the sale. They always understand where the buyer is during the buying process.

The leads that you will generate through your website will provide the key signals about where your customers are in the buying process.

Make sure that you don't implement a sales process in which someone in your sales organization calls every lead that downloads a white paper or registers to a webinar.

If you build your website and the system around it appropriately, the buyer will give you the buying signals you need.

Don't request a phone number until the buyer shows he is ready for a phone call by clicking on a button such as "free consultation" or "schedule a demo."

DON'T MISS OUT!

Don't ask for too much information in your landing pages, unless the buyer tells you he is ready

Don't switch your calls to action to "selling mode" too early in the campaign. Give the buyer the opportunity to get to know you better.

11. Upsells on every deal based on value

Present complementary products or services in every touch point. If you sell industrial equipment, for instance, present the products that go with them in your communications to your existing clients.

There may be times when you are so immersed in a particular project with your client that you don't have the opportunity to present the rest of your capabilities. However, your website and the communications that you set around it can do the job for you. Your clients will appreciate that you have taken the time to present products through a well-designed interactive experience.

DON'T MISS OUT!

Exploit your 2 column layout: use the side column for calls to action throughout your site

12. Keeps track of his own performance

Of course, the main purpose of your website is to help you sell more of your product. Make sure that all traffic and key points of conversion on your site are measurable.

Since your website will be your main marketing tool, make sure to design it so that you know which aspects of it are performing, and which ones are not.

Here are some of the key items you should measure:

- Traffic
- Traffic sources
- Popular keywords and your ranking position
- Popular pages
- Popular blog posts and advanced content pieces
- Best performing calls to action and landing pages
- Best performing email campaigns
- Leads generated from the site
- Sales generated from the site

DON'T MISS OUT!

You are never really done: keep working on improving the performance of your site.

If you can't measure the results of your web-site redesign, go back to the drawing board, you are doing this because you want to sell more

In Summary

By establishing the key elements of the ideal salesperson in your re-designed website, you will maximize your marketing performance, gain new customers and boost your bottom line. And, don't forget that your website will be able to go further than any salesperson by measuring the effectiveness of your online marketing campaigns – a tool that will provide you the information you need to continually refine your campaigns for the best results.

Additional Resources

Inbound Marketing Roadmap

These are 15 pages that will keep you sane when figuring out your overall online marketing initiatives from strategy and branding to results measurement.

- Learn all the components of an inbound marketing strategy
- Identify which activities are 1 time setup vs. ongoing
- Learn which initiatives should be pursued to generate traffic vs. improve conversion vs. performance improvement
- Clearly see which initiatives complement each other and make sense to do together
- Identify which initiatives are more effective if targeted to each customer persona
- Use the workbook format to initiate conversations with your team and share responsibilities in a logical way so that the effectiveness is not compromised when having too many people involved



MARKET 8 STUDIO, LLC
1016 HOWELL MILL RD. SUITE 2518
ATLANTA, GA 30318
P. +1 (678) 608-0605
F: +1 (678) 802-3429
WWW.MARKET8.NET
TWITTER: @MARKET_8